

Praise of the Buddha's Final Nirvāṇa

Buddhasya Nirvāṇastotram · Toh 1158 · Derge Tengyur

སངས་རྒྱལ་ཡོངས་སྐྱེ་བའི་ལོ་ལ་འདས་པ་ལ་བསྟོན་པ་

The Praise of the Buddha's Final Nirvāṇa, in Sanskrit Buddhasya Nirvāṇastotram and in Tibetan Sangyé Yongsu Nyangen Lé Depa La Töpa, is a short hymn in verse that its colophon attributes to the great master Dharmakīrti. It honors the Buddha at his passing, first recalling his birth among the Śākya, his awakening, his turning of the wheel of Dharma, and his final nirvāṇa in the sāl grove, and then mourning his departure with repeated cries of "Alas." Through a series of vivid images it laments the Buddha as a ford to the happy realms now run dry, a great tree fallen, a moon and a sun that have set, and a great elephant and a lion gone to peace, before closing by dedicating the merit of the praise so that the poet may benefit beings just as the Buddha did. It is Toh 1158 in the Tengyur, where it belongs to the section of praises (stotra).

In the language of India: buddhasya nirvāṇa stotraṃ

In the language of Tibet: Praise of the Buddha's Final Nirvāṇa

Homage to the youthful Mañjuśrī.

He who was born into the Śākya clan in Kapilavastu,
Who realized supreme awakening at Equal Joy,
Who turned the wheel of Dharma at Vārāṇasī,
And passed into nirvāṇa in the sāl grove: him I praise.

Alas, compassionate protector, Victor who stilled evil!
Alas, supreme and excellent charioteer of sentient beings, gentle and kind!
Alas, caravan leader, Teacher who became the path to peace!
Alas, kinsman of the world, even of mind toward the dear and the not dear!
Alas, eye of a world whose eyes are veiled by darkness!
Alas, Great Sage, who ferried the world across by boat!
Alas, why did you pass into nirvāṇa in the sāl grove?

Your face, like the full moon and the opened lotus,
Your very body, with eyes like blossoming blue lotuses,
Like a mountain of gold, complete with all the major marks: who shall see them?

Alas, not to see this supreme form, like light itself, is suffering.

In former times you built a raft whose nature was the vast path,
And accomplished your own benefit and the benefit of others, the great
multitude of beings;

You set many hundreds of living creatures in liberation and the higher realms.
Alas, by the massed fires of impermanence it has been consumed.

A wide pool of purity, brimming cool with the water of moral discipline,
Teeming with the water creatures of the perfect Buddha's Dharma,
Frequented by excellent monks and by hundreds of other assemblies:
Alas, to this ford to the happy realms, now run dry, I bow.

Firm in its roots of conduct, beautiful with its trunk of mindfulness,
Its flowers, the factors of awakening, open, its branches patience,
Lush with the leaves of modesty, bending deep with its fruit of nectar:
Alas, to the Sugata (the Buddha), the tree now fallen, I bow.

Resting serene in the dustless sky of nirvāṇa,
With its maṇḍala of stars, the disciples firm in moral discipline,
With lovely moonbeams that, for the eye of the mind, give birth to the noble
path:
Alas, to the Sugata, the moon now set, I bow.

Dispeller of the darkness of delusion, endowed with rays of good qualities,
Opening the lotuses in the pond of the hosts to be trained,
Drying up the mire, the stains of the sixty two views:
Alas, to the Sugata, the sun now set, I bow.

With a body of supreme love and four feet, the noble truths,
With two divine eyes, calm abiding and insight,
You went with the pure gait of liberation that inspires deep faith:
Alas, to the Sugata, the great elephant gone to peace, I bow.

Roaring that there are no sentient beings, crushing the deer, the
non-Buddhists (tīrthikas),
Your body adorned with a flowing mane, a mass of wonders,
With keen fangs of wisdom, and feet of virtuous moral discipline:
Alas, to the Sugata, the lion gone to peace, I bow.

O Buddha who have passed fully into nirvāṇa, by my praising you
Whatever vast merit of boundless fruit I have gathered,
Through it may I attain the supreme and sublime state
And, just like you, bring benefit to beings.

The Praise of the Buddha's Final Nirvāṇa, composed by the great master, the glorious Dharmakīrti, is complete.

Translator's Notes

- "Equal Joy" renders mnyam dga'. Its place in the first verse, between the Buddha's birth at Kapilavastu and his first teaching at Vārāṇasī, shows that it names the site of his awakening (Bodh Gayā), but this form of the name could not be identified, so it is translated literally.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.